the US Joint Chiefs of Staff, 'if I were going to pick the next attack to hit the United States, it would come out of the FATA.' Unfortunately, Pakistan's intelligence agencies could not predict the effects of FATA on Pakistan. Al Qaeda and TPP had already started their activities but they were not considered a threat to Pakistan by these agencies. This delay in understanding the severity of the situation in FATA affected Pakistan significantly. Ultimately, after several limited military operations against the insurgents, in 2014, the largest-ever internal military operation 'Zarb-e-Azb' had to be launched in North Waziristan Agency of FATA.

FATA includes the tribal areas adjoining the districts of Peshawar, Kohat, Bannu, Dera Ismail Khan and the seven agencies, Khyber, Kurram, Orakzai, Mohmand, Bajaur, North Waziristan and South Waziristan.[1] FATA is inhabited by seven main Pashtun tribes having a population of 3.2 million (Musharraf, 2006). The Pakistani courts and police have no jurisdiction in tribal areas. It is administered through the Political Agent (PA), the Maliks (tribal elders), *Jirga* (local elders' groups) and the Frontier Crimes Regulation (FCR) (Khyber, 2009).

Why and how FATA had acquired the reputation as the epicentre of terror is best explained by the following facts:

The primary reason for the rise of militancy in FATA could be safely attributed to the continually violent activities happening in Afghanistan for the last 30 years (Brynjar & Katja, 2000). From the fleeing Afghan refugees to the retreating fighters of Taliban and Al Qaeda, all managed to take shelter in FATA.

FATA was a convenient and natural sanctuary for the fleeing fighters from Afghanistan with a porous 2,500 km border with Afghanistan, called Durand Line, which could not be manned and monitored all along. It had been widely regarded as one of the most loosely maintained frontiers in the world, with tribesmen availing the historic right to cross it for centuries.

Moreover, the related tribesmen and even the Afghan nomads known as *pawandas* or *Kotchis* had been the immigration-free travellers between Pakistan and Afghanistan for ages (Matinuddin, 1999). Pakistan tried to establish a biometric system in January 2007, but the Afghan tribesmen, backed by the Afghan government, opposed it tooth and nail so that the system was discarded within days (*The News International*, 2011).

FATA, commonly known as '*Ilaqa Ghair*' (the area of others or the area beyond), had always been a safe haven for criminals, outlaws and